

Top of Mind

- Welcome to Fall 2026!
- [FILL OUT THIS FORM](#) so you can tell me if I'm giving you too much homework!

FCLC Undergraduate Introduction to Video Game Design Syllabus

- **Course Code:** CISC 2540
- **Schedule:** Tuesdays and Fridays, 1:00pm - 2:15pm
- **Instructor:** John Bezark
- **Office Hours:** Thursday 1-5pm. [Book here](#)

Course Description:

An introductory course exploring the fundamentals of digital game design and development. This course will use Godot 4.5 as the primary game creation tool, and it will cover the basics of game development, coding fundamentals, and game design principles. Students will engage in hands-on projects to develop practical skills in both 2D and 3D game design. Students are not expected to have any prior programming or game design experience.

Course Objectives:

- Understand the principles of game design and development.
- Gain proficiency in Godot 4.5.
- Develop basic coding skills relevant to game design.
- Complete three major game design projects: a tabletop game, a 2D game, and a capstone game.
- Enhance writing and oral presentation skills through game-related assignments.
- Be able to better work in teams
- Respond to critical feedback constructively

Assessment

The work of the class consists of the following:

Assignment	Description	Due Date	Points
Class Participation	Actively participate in class discussions and contribute to group projects.		15
Tabletop Game	A playable prototype of a tabletop game	Fri 9/11	16
Tabletop Game Process Paper	Paper which documents process, execution and playtesting of tabletop game	Tue 9/22	10
Labs 1-4	4 short coding assignments designed to build proficiency. 6 points each.	9/25, 10/2, 10/9, 11/6	24

Assignment	Description	Due Date	Points
2D Game Concept Paper	A brief paper describing your concept for the 2D Game	Tue 9/29	10
2D Game	A playable prototype of a 2D game	Fri 10/30	25
Capstone Concept Presentation	A brief Presentation describing your concept for the Capstone Game	Fri 11/13 or Tue 11/17	10
Game Review	Play one of the suggested games and review it!	12/8	10
Capstone Game	A polished game. Can be an evolution of the 2D game or something new.	Final	30
Total Points Possible			150

All assignments will be graded on the due date. Students are always allowed to revise and resubmit work **up until the class before the final**.

Attendance: Students are allowed 5 absences. After this, each unexcused absence will lower your final grade by 1/2 a letter, i.e. B+ -> B or A -> A-

Course Outline

The course is split into 3 distinct modules each with a unique project:

- Week 1-3: Game Design Fundamentals and tabletop design
- Week 4-9: 2D Game Design
- Week 10-15: 3D Game Design/Final Project Development

Welcome Week

Friday 8/28 (First class!)

- [Week 1 Slides](#)
- [FILL OUT THIS FORM](#) so you can tell me if I'm giving you too much homework!
- Who are you/Syllabus Review
- Professor John
- Game Design Fundamentals
- [What type of gamer are you?](#)

Homework: [Game Review](#)

Week 1 - Game Design Fundamentals

Tuesday 9/1

- The Iterative Game Design Process
- Prototyping
- Playtesting
- Group Work

Homework:

- [Tabletop Game](#)
- [Read MDA Article](#)

Friday 9/4

- Playtesting and Group Work time

Week 2 - Prototyping, Iteration and Playtesting

Tuesday 9/8

- [MDA Framework - Systems, Loops and Balance](#)
- Prototyping Tabletop Games: Balancing and Mechanics
- Reading: MDA
- MDA Framework
- Systems, Loops and Balance

Friday 9/11

- Playtesting
- [Git Init](#)

DUE: Tabletop Game Homework: [Tabletop Process Paper](#)

Week 3 - Playtesting and Intro to Godot

Tuesday 9/15

- Playtesting
 - [Video tutorial on Github and Godot](#)
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Friday 9/18 - Nodes and Scenes Workshop

- Hello Godot
 - Getting started with Godot
 - Nodes and Scenes - build a simple scene together

Homework: [Lab 1](#)

Week 4 - Nodes, Scenes and Coding Fundamentals

Tuesday 9/22 - Github and Genres

- [Genres in 2D](#)
 - [2D Game Brainstorming](#)
- Github Accounts, Cloning, Committing and pushing, Repo Creation

DUE: Process Paper Homework: [2D Game Concept](#) Homework: [2D Game](#)

Friday 9/25 - Coding Fundamentals

- Coding Fundamentals
 - Scripts and properties
 - Variables
 - Create a moving character together using simple_character example

DUE: Lab 1 Homework: [Lab 2](#)

Week 5 - Input and Interactions

Tuesday 9/29

- Coding review and workshop

DUE: [2D Game Concept](#)

Friday 10/2 - Input and Interactions

- Coding Input and Conditional Review
- Input map
- Shared Repos
 - Create, Invite, Clone
 - Pull and Push
 - Conflicts

DUE: Lab 2 Homework: [Lab 3](#)

Week 6 - Nodes, Assets and Animations

Tuesday 10/6 - Using Nodes Together

- Conditional Logic Review
- Using Nodes together
 - Calling Down
 - Area2D
 - Timer
 - Camera
 - Sound

Friday 10/9 - Assets and Animations

- Assets
 - Sprite Sheets
- Functions vs Signals
 - CollisionShapes
 - StaticBody
 - RigidBody

DUE: Lab 3

Week 7 - Break Week

Tuesday 10/13 - NO CLASS

- Columbus Day observed Monday 10/12; Tuesday classes follow a Monday schedule.

Friday 10/16 - CLASS CANCELLED

- **Work on your 2D games asynchronously**
- Project Development on your own time

Week 8 - Level, Environment and UI Design

Tuesday 10/20 - Patterns, Components and Polish

- Physics Objects
- CharacterBody
- Tilemaps
- UI
- Sounds
- 2D Components and Polish
 - Common Patterns: Items, Enemies, Checkpoints, Respawns, Killboxes
 - User Interface (Control Nodes)
 - Polish: Sound, Lighting, Particles
- Project Development

Friday 10/23

- Project Development

Week 9 - Playtesting and 2D Game Sprint

Tuesday 10/27

- Playtesting day!
- Project Development

Friday 10/30 - SPOOOOOKY HALLOWEEN 3D

DUE: 2D Game

Week 10 - Hello 3D

Tuesday 11/3

- Hello 3D
- Project Development

Homework: [Lab 4](#) Homework: [Capstone Game](#) Homework: [Capstone Presentation](#)

Friday 11/6

- Capstone Brainstorm
- Materials, Models
- Light, Sound

DUE: Lab 4

Week 11 - Advanced Topics and Capstone Presentations

Tuesday 11/10

- Classes, Resources
- Animated Characters
- NPCs
- Navigation

Friday 11/13

- **Capstone Presentations**

Week 12 - Capstone Presentations and Project Development

Tuesday 11/17

- **Capstone Presentations**
- Exporting
- Review

Friday 11/20

- Project Development

Week 13 - Project Development

Tuesday 11/24

- Project Development

Friday 11/27 - NO CLASS (Thanksgiving Recess)

Week 14 - Playtesting

Tuesday 12/1

- Final project playtest
- Project Development

Friday 12/4

- Project Development

Week 15

Tuesday 12/8 (Last day of classes)

- Final project playtest

DUE: Game Review

Finals Week (12/11 - 12/18)

Capstone and Beyond - Final Exam slot (see Fordham final exam schedule)

- Preparing for the Game Industry: Portfolio and Career Paths
- Playtest party!
- **DUE: Capstone Project**

Necessary Materials:

- [Godot 4.5](#) : An [open source](#) 2D, 3D and XR game engine.
- [Github Desktop](#): an industry standard [version control](#) system

Resources and Tutorials

- [Video tutorial on Github and Godot](#)
- [Introduction to Coding](#)
- [Conditionals and Input](#)
- [9 Ways to Actually Get Game Dev Done On Time](#)
- [Godot Resources](#)
- [Where do game ideas come from](#)

Godot

- [GDScript Cheat Sheet](#)
- [Source Code](#)
- [Docs](#)
- [Demo Projects](#)
- [Forums](#)
- [Godot Discord](#)
- [Learn GDScript From Zero](#)
- **TUTORIALS**

Brackeys

- [How to make a video game in Godot](#)
- [GDScript in 1 Hour](#)
- [How to make 3D Games in Godot](#)
- [Lighting in Godot](#)

Git & Github

- [Dan Shiffman's Github for Poets](#)

Instructor Details

John Bezark (they/them) is a Brooklyn based Game Designer, Creative Technologist, Immersive Experience Designer and Video Artist. They graduated from NYU's ITP with an MPS in Interactive Telecommunications and from Fordham University with a BA in Theatrical Directing. John has made everything from Solar Powered Websites to Immersive Game-shows about Systems Thinking.

Nowadays they like to use the Godot Game Engine to create one of a kind immersive and interactive experiences, games and performance art.

When not creating weird things, John also really likes to work in education and he's passionate about teaching others how to design immersive spaces, how to make games and how to see the world through the lens of Systems Thinking.

Email: jbezark@fordham.edu [Portfolio](#)

Office Hours: Thursday 1-5pm. [Book here](#)